



01

Yellow
**MAYA'S
STORY**

Only 10% → 0%

of Malawians had
electric light at night

of that was solar
in 2018

Growing up in East Africa, Maya Khonje-Stewart witnessed energy poverty first-hand. In 2012, she founded an NGO to promote solar in Malawi — but awareness alone could not solve the problem. She wanted to transform daily life for Malawian households.

Then she met Mike, a South African entrepreneur.

Established PAYGO companies had written off Malawi as too poor for the model to work. But Maya and Mike saw something others missed: low-income households were already spending heavily on dirty, unreliable energy. If Yellow could operate leanly enough, solar could be both affordable and commercially viable.

In March 2018, Mike raised the capital, Maya readied the team, and Yellow began work in Malawi.

02

MARCH 2018: THE LAUNCH

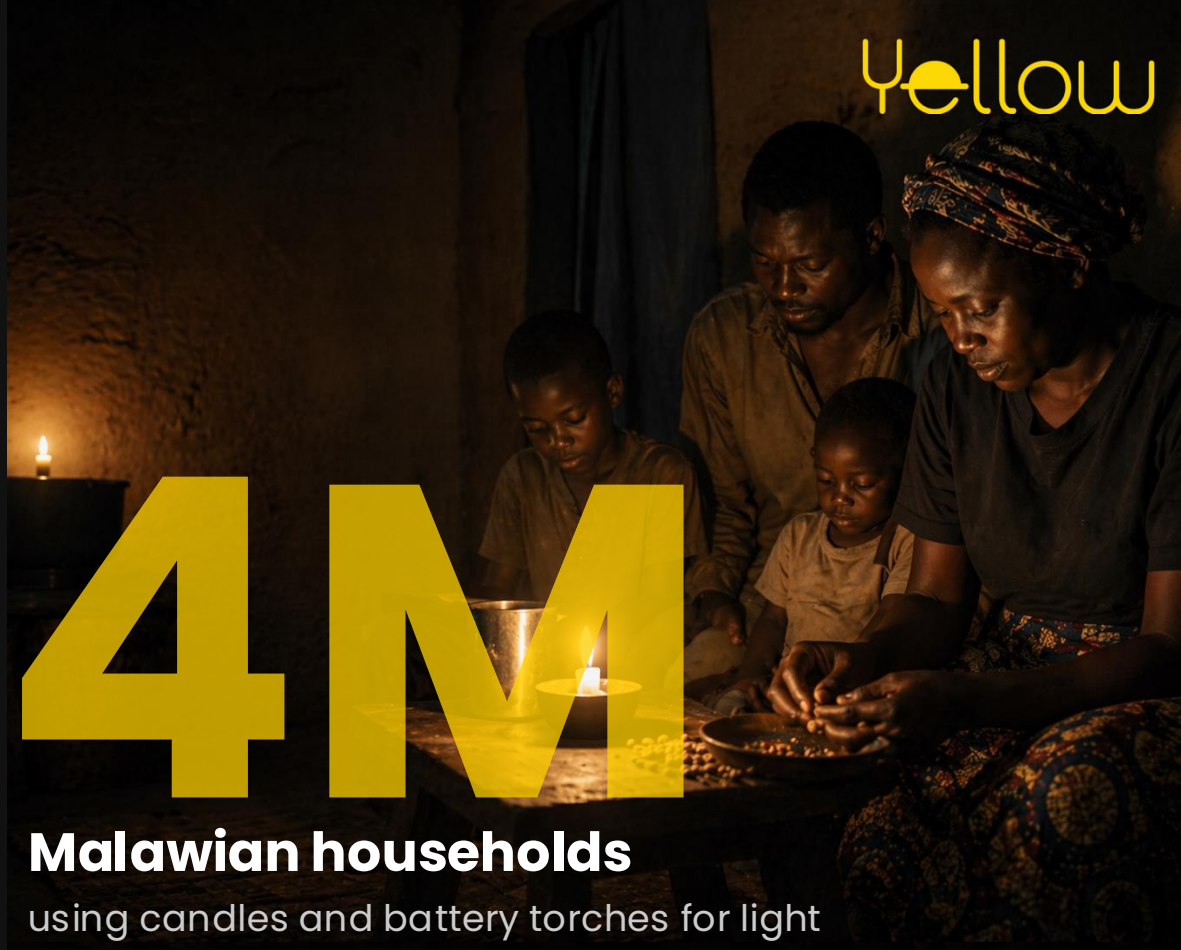
As social entrepreneurs, the prospect of making life better for these customers was incredibly exciting for Mike and Maya.

The mission was clear: bring affordable, reliable power to households living without electricity.

But the launch was harder than expected. Customers hesitated to pay deposits for small solar systems. Rural operations were chaotic. Execution was inconsistent. And early credit performance fell well below target.

The opportunity was real — but the model was not yet working.

Yellow needed to innovate.



4M

Malawian households

using candles and battery torches for light

- Walking miles to charge feature phones
- Solar penetration close to 0%
- Malawi: the lowest-income country in the world

03

THE DIGITAL BREAKTHROUGH

40 sales in 6 months ➡ **40 customers / day**

Yellow's breakthrough came from digitizing the operating model.

Inspired by the rise of tech-enabled platforms, Yellow turned manual processes into digital workflows — from agent management and customer onboarding to payments, service, and credit monitoring.

Automation lowered costs, improved execution, and helped Yellow find the right price point. Sales grew from 40 in six months to 40 customers per day. Service improved, and Yellow's agent-led credit model drove near-universal repayment.

Yellow



Yellow digitized its distribution and agent network — the turning point that unlocked scale in Malawi.

04

Yellow

When the innovation came,
so did the customers:

350,000

households electrified in five years
Equivalent to all connections from the national grid.

NPS 83

Exceptional customer
satisfaction
by 2022.

#1 brand

A household name in
rural Malawi by 2022.

Profitable

Within one year of
operating.



05

THE 2022 CRISIS

Capital evaporated from emerging markets. Malawi was among the worst hit.

FEB 2022**MAR 2022****2022-2024****2025**

**Russia invades
Ukraine**

**The Fed begins raising
interest rates**

**Emerging-market
capital dries up;
Kwacha depreciates
sharply**

**Lenders stop
taking Kwacha risk**

IMPACT

Yellow had hedged its Kwacha exposure, but by 2025 lenders were no longer willing to take local currency risk. Without working capital, the Malawi business could not order stock. Agents soon ran out of products to sell. A business that had proven its model now faced a liquidity crisis.

06

ACUMEN STEPS IN

When capital markets collapsed, Acumen delivered on its mandate.

At a moment when no other financial partner would take the risk, Acumen provided a timely debt facility, followed by grant funding to support e-waste recycling.

That support helped Yellow keep 1,000 agents active, retain more than 100 team members, and protect the health of its credit portfolio.

Today, Yellow Malawi is growing again — serving around 200 new customers per day and preparing to deliver against the World Bank's energy-access programme targets.

1,000

agents kept
active

100+

team members
retained

200/day

new customers
served



Some of our 1000+ Malawian agents at
a Yellow team-building event.

07

YELLOW'S FUTURE

10M

customers by 2030

What began as Maya's dream to bring clean, affordable energy to Malawian households has become a diversified, commercially sustainable business.

By 2030, Yellow aims to serve 10 million customers — and build the commercial engine that makes life better for everyday African households.

With 1 million total customers expected this quarter, operations across seven African markets, and \$80 million in funded solar and smartphone assets from an initial \$3 million equity base, Yellow is entering its next phase of scale.

1M total customers

Expected this quarter

7 African markets

diversified and profitable operations

\$3M equity → \$80M funded

life-changing solar & smartphone assets

Now becoming AI-native, Yellow is using technology to push prices down and service levels up.